

Proxy server

A system that caches items from other servers to speed up access. On the Web, a proxy first attempts to find data locally, and if it's not there, it fetches it from the remote server where the data resides.

QoS

Quality of Service. QoS can be used to describe any number of ways in which a network provider guarantees a service's performance, such as an average or minimum throughput rate.

RADIUS

Remote Authentication Dial-In User Service. The RADIUS is a server database used by an ISP to authenticate users who are trying to log on to the service. It can also track network usage.

RJ-11

Registered Jack 11. This is the standard telephone connector—a tab snaps into the socket and has to be pressed to remove the connector from the wall or your phone. An ordinary phone circuit uses two wires. The RJ-11 jack has room for up to four wires.

RJ-45

Registered Jack 45. RJ-45 connectors look a bit like standard phone connectors (RJ-11) but are twice as wide, with eight wires. RJ-45s are used for hooking up computers to LANs or for phones with lots of lines.

Router

As the name indicates, this piece of hardware routes data from one local area network to another or to a phone line's long-distance line. Routers also act as traffic cops, allowing only authorized machines to transmit data into the local network so that private information can remain secure. In addition, routers handle errors, keep network usage statistics, and handle security issues.